DATA MINIMISATION GUIDE

Data Minimisation: A Practical Privacy Guide for Students and Research Services
Topic: Privacy and Data Protection

1. Purpose and Introduction

Data minimisation is the practice of collecting and keeping only the personal information that is necessary for a specific purpose. Organisations should not collect extra information simply because it might be useful in the future.

Students and research services may collect names, email addresses, course details, survey responses and other personal information. Collecting too much data can increase the risk of data leaks, misuse, identity theft and unauthorised access.

The purpose of this guide is to explain how student-facing services and research teams can reduce unnecessary data collection while still completing their work effectively.

Main principle: Collect only what is needed, explain why it is needed, protect it properly and delete it when it is no longer required.

2. Why Is Data Collected?

Personal information should be collected for a clear and legitimate purpose.

Examples include:

- Student registration: collecting a name and student ID to identify a student.
- Workshop registration: collecting a name and contact detail to send event updates.
- Research surveys: collecting responses required to answer a research question.
- Feedback forms: collecting feedback to improve a service.

Before collecting information, the team should ask:

1. What is the exact purpose of collecting this information?
2. Can the purpose be achieved without collecting personal information?
3. Which fields are genuinely necessary?
4. Who needs access to the information?
5. How long must the information be retained?

If a field does not serve a clear purpose, it should normally be removed.

3. What Information Is Necessary?

Information is necessary when it directly supports the stated purpose and there is no reasonable, less intrusive alternative.

For example, a workshop registration form may need a participant's name and email address. It usually does not need their home address, government identity number or family income.

Research teams should also consider whether they can use anonymous responses, participant codes or grouped statistics instead of identifiable records.

However, data minimisation does not mean collecting too little information to conduct valid research. Researchers should collect the information genuinely required by their approved research method and explain any sensitive or unusual requirements.

4. Retention: How Long Should Data Be Kept?

Data should not be stored indefinitely without a valid reason. A retention period should be decided before collection, taking account of the purpose, applicable law, institutional rules and research requirements.

Practical recommendations:

- Define a retention period for each category of information.
- Keep contact details separate from research responses where practical.
- Review stored information periodically.
- Delete or anonymise information when it is no longer needed.

- Document any justified retention extensions.

Fictional example: A student workshop team needs email addresses to send event updates. It decides to delete the registration contact list 30 days after the workshop, unless a documented requirement justifies keeping some records longer.

This is an illustrative policy, not a universal legal retention period.

5. Access Control and Secure Storage

Only authorised people should access personal information, and access should be limited to what they need for their role.

Recommended practices:

- Give each team member an individual account.
- Use role-based permissions and the principle of least privilege.
- Protect accounts with strong passwords and multifactor authentication where available.
- Store records in approved, access-controlled systems.
- Avoid sharing personal data through public links or personal messaging accounts.
- Review permissions when a team member leaves or changes responsibilities.
- Never include passwords, API keys or identifiable participant data in public repositories.

For example, a research assistant who analyses survey responses may not need access to participants' names or email addresses.

6. Consent, Privacy Notices and Transparency

People should be told clearly what information is being collected and why. A privacy notice should use simple language and be available before or at the point of collection.

A useful notice explains:

- What information is being collected.
- Why it is required and how it will be used.
- Whether providing it is optional or necessary.
- Who may access it or receive it.
- How long it will be kept.
- How people can ask questions or exercise applicable privacy rights.

Where consent is the appropriate legal basis, it should be informed, specific and freely given, and withdrawal should be handled as explained in the notice. Consent is not the only possible legal basis in every situation, so organisations must determine the correct basis for their activity.

Research involving people should also follow applicable ethics approval, participant-information and confidentiality requirements. Refusing optional data collection should not result in unfair treatment.

7. Safe Deletion and Disposal

When personal information is no longer required, it should be securely deleted or irreversibly anonymised, subject to applicable retention obligations.

For digital records:

- Delete unnecessary files and records from approved systems.
- Empty recycle bins or follow the organisation's secure-deletion procedure where appropriate.
- Check shared folders, duplicate exports and other managed copies.
- Apply the organisation's retention and deletion rules to backups.
- Record the deletion where a record of disposal is required.

For paper records:

- Use secure shredding or an approved confidential-waste service.
- Do not leave forms containing personal information in open bins.

Deleting a file from one folder may not remove copies in backups, email attachments or other systems. Follow the relevant system's deletion process and confirm completion where possible.

8. Practical Data Minimisation Process

1. **Define the purpose:** Write down why the data is needed.
2. **List the fields:** Identify every item of information proposed for collection.
3. **Justify each field:** Keep only fields necessary for the purpose.
4. **Inform participants:** Provide a clear privacy notice and obtain consent where appropriate.
5. **Restrict access:** Give access only to authorised people.
6. **Set retention rules:** Decide when the data will be reviewed, deleted or anonymised.
7. **Review and improve:** Remove unnecessary fields and check that the process is followed.

9. Conclusion

Data minimisation is an important part of responsible privacy and data protection. Collecting less personal information reduces exposure, makes records easier to manage and helps build trust with students and research participants.

Every student service and research team should be able to explain why each field is collected, who can access it and when it will be deleted. The safest practical approach is to collect only necessary information, protect it throughout its lifecycle and dispose of it securely when the purpose has been fulfilled.

References

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